



Silver lining: India's Yogesh Kathuniya celebrates his silver medal in the men's F56 discus at the Tokyo 2020 Paralympics in Japan. GETTY IMAGES

it. That was the day I decided I wanted to be an athlete. Even then, I was torn between sport and a career as a CA. It wasn't until I watched the 2016 Rio Paralympics that I knew I needed a proper coach. I found one in Satyapal Singh at JLN Stadium.

My days became intense: leaving home at 4 a.m., taking a bus to the stadium, training for hours, heading to classes, then hitting the gym in the

evening. Sometimes I travelled ticketless just to save money for my diet. I even gave tuition classes to cover expenses. People often asked why I, a disabled person, was working so hard. I'd just laugh and say, "Sports is my medicine."

Results didn't come immediately. It took a year before I won my first national titles — gold in discus, shot put, and javelin at the 2018 Nationals. That was a turning point.

I've had my share of recognition since then — the Arjuna Award after Tokyo, for instance. But I've also felt overlooked. After Paris, I wasn't given any award, even though I had scored

more points than some athletes who were recognised. I don't begrudge Manu Bhaker the Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna, but I couldn't help feeling treated differently. Too often, para athletes are met with sympathy instead of empathy. Some people don't like that I speak about it, but I will never stop telling the truth.

As long as I perform, no one can silence me. My goals have grown since I first started. In 2022, I set a world record of 48.34m. Now, I want to go beyond 50m before I retire. If I can do it in New Delhi, in front of my family, there would be nothing like it.

As told to Jonathan Selvaraj